

ANI

ONCE UPON A TIME
Ashok Gehlot with Sachin Pilot (right)

Congress victory in Karnataka has been massive and has rejuvenated the party leadership and workers across India. This is the second such win against Prime Minister Narendra Modi's BJP in less than six months—it won Himachal Pradesh in December 2022. Many within the party and outside have begun to see this as a revival of the Congress and decline of the Modi magic, which has helped the BJP win two consecutive Lok Sabha polls with massive mandates and form governments in several states as well. Even other Opposition leaders, including West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee and Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav, who were unwilling to yield the leading space to the Congress, have now changed tune, and have hinted at the possibility of joining hands with the Congress for a larger front against the BJP, provided the Congress allows the regional parties to lead in the regions where they are in command.

Such political inferences, however, don't enthuse Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge. When reporters asked him if the Karnataka win was Modi's loss as the BJP had centred its election campaign around the prime minister, Kharge dismissed the question saying that this victory was about the state and not the Lok Sabha next year. The octogenarian politician, with nearly 60 years in active politics, understands that there are several battles to be won in the run-up to 2024. And such victories against the BJP in the state are not new. In the 57 state elections that it has contested since May 2014, the BJP has lost 29.

In 2018, the Congress won and formed governments in three states—Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh—that together account for 65 Lok Sabha seats. Yet, in 2019, it could win only three of these Lok Sabha seats, a repeat of its performance in 2014. It even lost its government in MP in 2020, after Jyotiraditya Scindia, peeved at being ignored for the post of chief minister, defected to the BJP along with 22 MLAs. These three states, where the Congress and the BJP are locked in bipolar contests, will go to the polls later this year. The Congress would be defending turfs in two of them—Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh—and will be the prime challenger in MP.

These battles in the states will not be easy for any of the parties as all of them face internal conflicts, anti-incumbency, imbalance in caste equations and corruption charges. The Karnataka victory of the Congress and the BJP's abysmal failure have demonstrated the key components that determine the difference between the winner and the loser—right narrative, strong leadership, deft handling of internal conflicts, social engineering and powerful communication. How the political parties work on these individual components is likely to determine the results of the electoral battles later this year in the three states.

WHILE THE CONGRESS WAS CELEBRATING ITS KARNATAKA VICTORY, PILOT WAS LEADING A MARCH IN RAJASTHAN, HIGHLIGHTING THE FAILURE OF THE GOVT OF HIS OWN PARTY TO CURB CORRUPTION

RAJASTHAN
Crisis of Leadership

This is one state where both the Congress and the BJP have been unable to successfully resolve the issue of leadership. Ever since Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot took oath in 2018, the ruling Congress has witnessed a bitter public feud between him and his former deputy, Sachin Pilot. Even when the party was celebrating its Karnataka victory, Pilot was leading a march in Rajasthan, highlighting the failure of the government of his own party to curb corruption, and recruitment test paper leaks. On May 16, the march culminated in Jaipur with his aide, minister Rajendra Singh Gudha, accusing his own government of surpassing the outgoing '40 per cent' BJP *sarkar* in Karnataka. Ironically, it was the Congress campaign against the alleged corrupt practices under BJP rule in the southern state that caught the fancy of the voters.

However, despite Pilot's rebellion, Gehlot has kept a firm grip on the party, with most MLAs backing his leadership. That's one reason why the party high command has not yet yielded to Pilot's demand to make him the CM. Gehlot is now banking on his welfare schemes—he regularly monitors